



the people, however, still speak the Chukchi language in their own home and it is now classified as an endangered language. It was originally just a spoken language but in 1932 it was written down for the first time.

Although the area that they live in is now inhabited by other peoples, some Chukchi have remained very traditional in their lifestyle. The word “Chukchi” means “rich in reindeer.”

## Spiritual belief

Like many Arctic peoples, the Chukchi have an animistic religion—they believe that every object, whether animate or not, possesses a spirit or life force that may be beneficial or harmful. They believe that these spirits roam the Earth, and everyday tasks, such as hunting and fishing, include certain customs intended to make the hunt successful and all the spirits happy.



### RESPECTING THE DEAD

A common Arctic belief is that a hunted animal gives itself to the hunter and in return the spirit of the animal must be treated with respect. This child is giving the dead seal a drink of water.



Wooden idol

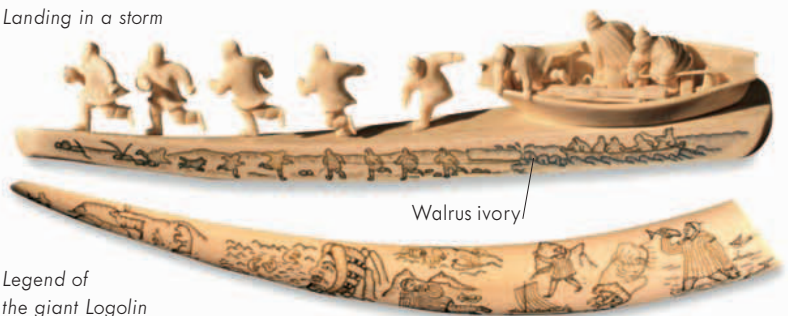
### REINDEER PROTECTION

The Chukchi make reindeer idols out of deer skin and wood, and sometimes decorate them with beads. These idols are created to protect the reindeer and keep them from harm. If one of the herd gets lost, the Chukchi take out the idols and beat them in the belief that this encourages the spirits to send the reindeer back unhurt.

## IVORY LEGENDS

The Chukchi people are well known for their beautiful carvings and engravings. They carve figures from myths and legends out of walrus ivory or whale bone. The people of the tundra tell many folk stories that involve personified wild animals, such as the raven and the Arctic fox.

Landing in a storm



Walrus ivory

Legend of the giant Logolin

## SHAMANISM

Traditional Chukchi people believe in shamans, figures who are capable of communicating directly with spiritual powers, often in ecstatic states. The drum is the only instrument that the Chukchi people have and it is always used in conjunction with a shaman.



The drum is made out of reindeer skin.